

How can we distinguish between good and bad interpretations? Discuss with reference to the arts and one other area of knowledge.

A good interpretation must come to a conclusion or way of understanding through evidence displayed in the medium. All personal interpretations must have a degree of subjectivity in them because all interpretations are from a personal perspective. However, one cannot rely solely on their interpretation if it derives from a personal reaction or opinion while discarding all other evidence and information. A bad interpretation is not supported with evidence through the medium. For instance, if most people agree on an interpretation derived from the object, then they solely base their interpretation on emotion, which can be deduced as a bad interpretation. An interpretation from a subjective perspective would be bad if it was the only justification, which deviates from the value of evidence rooted in the source. When comparing the arts and the natural sciences use of good and bad interpretations when reaching conclusions differs from one another.

According to Henry M. Sayre in his book *A World of Art*, there are four roles traditionally assigned to artists. They were to produce a record of their surroundings; to express emotions in a tangible or visible manner; to reveal truths that were either universal or hidden, and to help people view the world from a different or novel perspective.¹ Artists often leave room for the viewer to interpret their work; however, these interpretations are subjective as each viewer perceives the same piece differently. For example, Roger Ebert, an American film critic, made a controversial claim stating that “video games can never be art.” While he was attending a TED talk given at USC by video game designer Kellee Santiago she began by stating that “video games are art.” This example portrays two expert opinions that conflict with one another, ergo

¹ Joyner, Jeffrey. “The Roles of Artists.” *Work*, 21 Nov. 2017, <https://work.chron.com/roles-artists-16082.html>.

who interpretation are we to believe? When Ebert made this claim, he was widely regarded as the most accurate and well-acclaimed movie critic during the 2010s; however, his claim had lost support over the years. Ebert corrects himself in his blog post, claiming that video gamers in 2010 will not survive long enough to experience gamers as a form of art. He claimed that video games do have the potential to achieve the same status of art. A key difference between Santiago's and Ebert's claim is that Santiago provides a definition of art for her reasoning, while Ebert does not. According to the artist's role, Santiago's claim is justified. Games that she references, such as *Waco Resurrection*, express the events that occurred in Waco, Texas, not as they accurately happened but how they felt and were perceived by society. Santiago solidifies her reasoning with evidence rooted in the games concerning the artist's role and the purpose of their medium, attributing to the qualifications for a good interpretation. Another example she used is a game called *Flower*, in which the creator of the game expresses his transition from urban China to urban California and tries to find a balance between the natural and metropolitan areas. Again, Santiago conveys a video game that captures their surroundings and tangibly expresses their emotions. Thus, her claim that "video games art" is justified by the evidence presented through the video game itself and the role of the artist, making her claim a good interpretation.

Despite the arts being open-ended for interpretation, it can also limit our understanding of knowledge. On May 3rd, 1963, MLK Jr came to Birmingham, Alabama, to speak during the Birmingham campaign and advocate for civil rights. As more people gathered, bystanders, protestors, and instigators, violence broke out between protestors and instigators. Eventually, the police came to control and relieve tension by gathering crowds. The police's job was to keep protestors and the crowd apart by using barricades and dogs. Walter Gaston was a tall 15-year-old and bystander witnessing MLK Jr's speech. Richard Middleton's dog pounces and

bites Gaston as he crosses the street. Middleton tries to restrain his dog and keep Gaston at a safe distance. At this moment, Bill Hudson captures a photo, which looks like Middleton is allowing his dog to attack the young teen. Several years later, Ronald Macdowell created a sculpture portraying an image that is arguably one of the most impactful photos from the civil rights movement. Macdowell artistically chose to make the child smaller, the police officer emotionless, and the dog to look like a wolf in the sculpture to emphasize the effects of the civil rights movement. Hudson and Macdowell's interpretation of the event can be justified as a good interpretation because their mediums express emotion and help people view society from a different perspective. As an interpreter, the message conveyed through the sculpture and photograph does not represent history accurately. However, it is not necessarily the interpreter's job to get at the truth or understand the work of art based on the evidence presented in the art. The artist's role, previously mentioned, does not mention that there is an obligation to represent history directly, rather how they have perceived the event. From a historical perspective, their depictions of the event are considered a bad interpretation because they did not record the objective truth. However, their depictions are forms of art and fall under the category of the artist's role. Therefore, an interpretation that derives from the mediums should be valued as a good interpretation because the piece of art supports it.

As part of the scientific method, scientists provide interpretations of the available data and findings to develop theories and formulate conclusions. Given the empirical nature of knowledge acquisition in the natural sciences, good interpretations are those strongly supported by the available data, while bad ones are not. However, in 2015 an experiment was conducted among twenty-nine researchers who were asked the same question with the same set of data in order to test the validity of crowdsourcing. The question asked was: are soccer referees more

likely to give red cards to players with dark skin than to players with light skin? This experiment highlights good and bad interpretations because it addresses broad issues, such as implicit bias and prejudice in sports. As a scientist, bias can affect their interpretation; therefore, it is difficult to rely solely on a single case study evaluation. Scientists in the experiment used statistical models such as Bayesian clustering to logistic regression and linear modeling. When consulting with the twenty-nine participating teams, they deemed some approaches less defensible than others. Thus, they can be considered a bad interpretation compared to the common knowledge of the scientific community. Twenty out of the twenty-nine teams found a statistically significant correlation between skin color and red cards. Therefore, this indicates that twenty of the teams yielded the same conclusion based on the same evidence. These twenty teams did not perform the same analytical approach; however, they could come to the same conclusion from the evidence presented. There must be a number of criteria that must be applied to result in a good interpretation; thus, it is a bad interpretation if not followed. The nine teams that came to a contradicting conclusion may have overlooked the underlying evidence and perceived their data with statistical bias. Not only does a good interpretation derive from the medium itself, but it can be further strengthened when multiple parties come to the same conclusion from the same evidence. When crowdsourcing evidence, greater certainty, and interpretations are seen rather than an independent review.

Correspondence with the available data may not be the best criteria and should focus on the interpretation's usefulness for further knowledge acquisition. In the 1700s, French naturalist George-Louis Leclerc initially estimated the Earth's age to be 75,000 years while still speculating it could be much older. After 1960, Charles Darwin's new theory of evolution also implied the Earth to be extremely old, providing time for the diversity of species to evolve.

Darwin speculated that the Earth was approximately 100 million years old, which was still off because he was unaware of radioactivity. While Darwin's interpretation of Earth's age was incorrect, he provided helpful speculation to build. Regardless of the accuracy of his interpretation due to lack of evidence, he was able to push future scientists in the correct direction concerning Earth's age. Despite the majority of good interpretations supported by evidence, an interpretation made from ambiguous and lack of evidence can still provide insight into a particular aspect of the natural sciences. When there is a considerable amount of data available, we should favor interpretations that fit best with it. However, more open-ended interpretations should be viewed more positively when limited research.

The purpose of interpretations as an artist is to convey a message or emotion through a tangible medium that reveals truths and different perspectives. In both areas of knowledge, bias is a critical factor that weighs the value of an interpretation as good or bad. However, the key point that derives from this paper is that the medium itself supports a good interpretation. Evidence provided in the object helps solidify an interpretation as good. A good interpretation from limited evidence can still be justified; however, it should be confirmed that the object reinforces a good interpretation while a bad interpretation is not.

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